Judge Says White House Cannot Ban Reporters Over Their News

From: NPR World Mined: 2026-10-14 3 min read

A **federal judge** ruled late Tuesday that President Trump cannot keep news reporters out of the White House just because he does not like what they report. The **ruling** lasts at least until the case goes to a full **trial**.

Last month, the government took away the White House passes of more than 70 reporters from CNN, MS NOW and Politico. The three news groups **sued**.

Judge Timothy J. Kelly said the ban likely broke the reporters' right to free speech. He said it also likely broke their right to a fair warning and a fair chance to object. Both rights are in the U.S. **Constitution**.

The government said the ban was about keeping the country safe. The judge did not agree. He pointed to the president's own words. He also said Trump's worries about fair news are not necessarily wrong.

A lawyer for the news groups praised the **ruling**. The White House did not answer right away.

Word Treasure

federal judge -- A judge who works in a U.S. national court.
ruling -- An official decision made by a judge.
trial -- A meeting in court where both sides explain their case and a decision is made.
sued -- Took someone to court to try to fix a problem.
Constitution -- The highest set of laws in the United States that protects people's rights.

Background you need

Reporters need special passes to work inside the White House and ask the president questions.

The U.S. Constitution protects free speech, which includes the right of news reporters to report what they see.

When people think their rights were broken, they can ask a judge to decide.

Break it down

WHO: Judge Timothy J. Kelly and reporters from CNN, MS NOW and Politico
WHAT: The judge ruled the White House cannot ban the reporters over what they report
WHERE: The White House in Washington, D.C.
WHY: The ban likely broke the reporters' rights to free speech and a fair chance to object

Why it matters

Free speech protects everyone's right to share and learn the news, including what kids read about their leaders.

Test what you remember

1. What did the judge say President Trump cannot do?

- (A) Hire new workers
- (B) Travel
- (C) Give speeches
- (D) Keep reporters out just because he dislikes their news

2. How many reporters lost their White House passes?

- (A) More than 70
- (B) Exactly 1,000
- (C) Two
- (D) About ten

3. Which news groups sued?

- (A) CNN, MS NOW and Politico
- (B) Three TV cartoons
- (C) Only one newspaper
- (D) A school paper

4. Where are the rights to free speech and a fair chance written?

- (A) In the U.S. Constitution
- (B) In a news story
- (C) In a comic book
- (D) On the White House door

5. What reason did the government give for the ban?

- (A) The passes were old
- (B) The reporters were late
- (C) There was no room
- (D) Keeping the country safe

6. How long does the ruling last?

- (A) One day
- (B) At least until the case goes to a full trial
- (C) Forever
- (D) Only on weekends

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: A 4: A 5: D 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Judge Timothy J. Kelly: Said the ban likely broke the reporters' rights, but Trump's worries about fair news are not necessarily wrong.
2. The government: Said the ban was about keeping the country safe.
3. Lawyer for the news groups: Praised the ruling.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):